

Student Meal Planner

Target Audience Research: Dutch Students and Meal Planning

A Concept Research Report for the Grubs4Scrubs Project

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Author: Yao Cheng Zhou

Introduction

Grubs4Scrubs is a meal planning app for students. That was the pitch from day one. But "students" is vague. A first-year living in student housing with a shared kitchen and 200 euros a month for food has completely different needs than a fourth-year with their own apartment and a part-time job. I needed to figure out who exactly I was building for, what their actual problems with food are, and what would make them use an app instead of just winging it every week.

This matters because every design decision flows from who the user is. The budget tracker, the recipe complexity, the meal planner layout, even the dark theme. All of that should fit the person using it. I did this research early in the project so I wouldn't build something based on guesses and then realize halfway through that I'd aimed at the wrong crowd.

Main Research Question

Who is the target audience for Grubs4Scrubs, and what are their specific needs around meal planning and food budgeting?

Sub-Questions, Methods, and Approach

I broke this into four sub-questions. The methods were mostly library research and looking at existing products, since running a full survey as a solo student project wasn't realistic on my timeline.

Who Are Dutch Students, Financially?

Sub-question: *What does the financial situation of the average Dutch student look like, and how much do they spend on food?*

Method: Library research using CBS (Statistics Netherlands) data and student surveys.

I looked at data from CBS and Nibud (the Dutch national budget institute) on student income and spending. They publish yearly breakdowns of what students earn from loans, jobs, and parental support, and where that money goes. Food is one of the biggest categories after rent, so the numbers are tracked pretty well.

What Problems Do Students Have With Cooking?

Sub-question: *What specific challenges do students face when it comes to cooking and meal planning?*

Method: Community research, looking at student forums and social media discussions.

I browsed Reddit threads (r/studentfood, r/thenetherlands), student Facebook groups, and forum posts about cooking as a student. The goal was to find recurring complaints and patterns. Not scientific data, but honest insight into what people actually struggle with when they're trying to feed themselves on a budget.

What Existing Apps Target This Audience?

Sub-question: *What meal planning or budget cooking apps already exist, and how well do they serve students?*

Method: Available product analysis, comparing features of existing apps.

I downloaded and tested several meal planning apps: Mealime, Whisk, Eat This Much, and Budget Bytes. I looked at whether they had budget tracking, simple recipes, shopping lists, and whether they felt aimed at students or at a more general (often older, higher-income) audience. Most of them didn't hit the student use case well.

What Features Would Actually Get Used?

Sub-question: *Based on the audience's needs, which features should Grubs4Scrubs prioritize?*

Method: Best good and bad practices analysis, cross-referencing audience needs with competitor gaps.

I took what I'd learned about student problems and compared it to what existing apps offer. The gaps between "what students need" and "what current apps provide" became the feature list for Grubs4Scrubs. This is where the MoSCoW prioritization came from.

Results: Sources Reviewed

Nibud: Student Budget Guide

Nibud publishes detailed budget advice for Dutch students. According to their 2024 figures, students living independently spend roughly 150 to 250 euros per month on food, depending on whether they eat out regularly. The guide breaks down a typical weekly grocery budget and notes that students who plan their meals tend to spend less than those who buy food day by day. This confirmed that budget tracking belongs in the app.

CBS (Statistics Netherlands): Student Income Data

CBS data shows that the average Dutch student's income comes from a mix of study financing, part-time work, and parental contributions. After rent (which eats the biggest chunk), food is the second or third largest expense. The data makes it clear that small savings on food add up significantly for students, since there's very little slack in the budget.

Reddit and Student Forums: Common Complaints

The recurring themes across student food communities were consistent. People complained about not knowing what to cook, buying ingredients that go to waste, eating the same three meals on repeat, and not having time to plan. A surprising number of posts were about the mental load of deciding what to eat every day, not just the cooking itself. Students want someone (or something) to just tell them what to make.

Mealime, Whisk, and Budget Bytes: Competitor Analysis

Mealime is the closest to what Grubs4Scrubs tries to do. Clean interface, meal planning, auto-generated shopping lists. But it doesn't track budget at all. Whisk has recipes but the meal planning is buried. Budget Bytes has budget-friendly recipes but no planning tools. None of them combine budget tracking with meal planning in a way that feels designed for students. The gap is real.

Nibud: Student Spending Patterns Report

A separate Nibud report on spending patterns shows that students who track their expenses (in any category) tend to spend 10 to 15 percent less than those who don't. The same pattern probably applies to food. If Grubs4Scrubs shows users what their weekly meal plan costs before they go shopping, it creates a natural feedback loop: see the number, adjust the plan, spend less.

Conclusion: Sub-Questions

Dutch Student Finances, Answered

The average Dutch student living independently has 150 to 250 euros a month for food. That's tight. There's not much room for waste, impulse buys, or expensive ingredients. Any app targeting this audience needs to make budget visibility a core feature, not an afterthought. If I can show someone their weekly meal cost before they go to the store, that alone has value.

Student Cooking Problems, Answered

The biggest issues aren't really about cooking skill. They're about decision fatigue (what do I eat today?), food waste (bought too much, didn't use it), repetition (same pasta every night), and time (don't want to spend an hour planning). Students want something that reduces the mental effort of feeding themselves. Quick recipes with short ingredient lists and a plan they can just follow.

Existing App Gaps, Answered

No app I tested combines budget tracking with meal planning for a student audience. Mealime comes closest on the planning side but ignores budget. Budget Bytes has cheap recipes but no planner. The opportunity for Grubs4Scrubs is in the overlap: plan your week, see the cost, get a shopping list. That combination doesn't exist in a student-friendly package right now.

Feature Priorities, Answered

Must-haves based on the research: recipe browsing with budget info visible, a weekly meal planner, estimated cost per week, and a generated shopping list. Should-haves: recipe filtering (dietary needs, meal type), Google login for convenience. Could-haves: rating recipes, sharing meal plans. The priorities came directly from matching student pain points to what's missing in existing apps.

Conclusion: Main Question

The target audience for Grubs4Scrubs is Dutch students aged 17 to 25, living independently (student housing or apartments), with a food budget of roughly 150 to 250 euros per month. Their main problems aren't cooking skill but decision fatigue, food waste, and lack of budget visibility. They want something that tells them what to cook, keeps costs visible, and generates a shopping list so they can just go to the store without thinking too hard about it.

For Grubs4Scrubs, this means the meal planner and budget tracker are the core of the app, not secondary features. Recipes need to be quick (under 30 minutes), cheap (under 5 euros per serving), and use common ingredients. The UI should be simple and fast because students won't spend ten minutes setting up a meal plan. Every design decision I made during the project traces back to this audience: the dark theme (students use their phones at night), the clean card layout (scan quickly, pick a recipe), the cost shown on every recipe card (budget is always top of mind).

Summary

Grubs4Scrubs targets Dutch students living on their own with limited food budgets. Their problems are decision fatigue, food waste, and not knowing what meals cost until they're at the checkout. Existing apps don't combine meal planning with budget tracking for this demographic. The feature priorities (meal planner, budget visibility, shopping list, quick cheap recipes) came directly from matching audience needs to competitor gaps.

References

All references are formatted in APA 7th edition style.

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